Security Alliance

OPSEC While Traveling

v1.0

Your friendly travel security companion

the red guild

OPSEC

WHILE TRAVELING

v1.0

Your friendly travel security companion

by **The Red Guild** & **SEAL**

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ABOUT – **THE RED GUILD**

A non-profit organization, think-tank-alike, devoted to do security as a public good within the Ethereum ecosystem. Its work spans security research, responsible disclosure, education, open-source tooling, community awareness and more. It is best known for developing gamified learning experiences like **Damn Vulnerable DeFi,** and their recent platform the **Phishing Dojo**.

Learn more at **theredguild.org**
blog.theredguild.org · phishingdojo.com

ABOUT – **SECURITY ALLIANCE**

Security Alliance (SEAL) is a nonprofit organization dedicated to securing the future of cryptocurrency. Under the leadership of renowned whitehat hacker **samczsun**, the organization designs innovative security projects and coordinates across the crypto industry to ensure meaningful adoption of security best practices.

Learn more at **securityalliance.org**

About this book

Hi reader! o/

This mini-book is an adaptation from the travel security guide from the **Security Frameworks**, an initiative by the **Security Alliance**. The majority of the content was initially drafted by me and peer reviewed by other members of **The Red Guild** and **SEAL**.

Part of the contents are inspired and based on resources from CISA GOV, Cornell University, Unchained, Cypherock, Schneier, The Mac Guys,

BlackCloak, Trio, Travel and Leisure, Washington Post among others that are cited.

Help us improve!

Suffice to say this is a work in progress and an experiment! After receiving a lot of positive feedback on the original guide I originally drafted for frameworks, it seemed like a handy travel guide was a no brainer.

I acknowledge most of this guide may not be representative for the majority. Things move fast in crypto security. Nonetheless, my peers and I deemed it crucial to

improve Operational Security practices for individuals.

When someone asks me about what they should do under a specific situation I always defer to the best possible answer non-answer: "Well... it all depends on your threat model". Now I can save myself 8 words by handing them this mini-book.

— matta

Founder @ **The Red Guild**

Initiative Lead & Technical Council @ **SEAL**

If you value these type of resources, please consider supporting them. You can do so by going to our website. securityalliance.org/donate

Introduction

Travel introduces unique security risks to your digital assets and sensitive information. Proper preparation before, vigilance during, and careful review after travel creates a comprehensive defense strategy that balances safety with practical usability.

When we travel, our normal security routines are disrupted, and we face elevated risks from physical theft, digital surveillance, border inspections, and social engineering.

Web3 professionals face additional challenges when traveling with crypto assets, access to treasury funds, or sensitive repositories.

The resources in this mini-book provide practical guidance for maintaining operational security while traveling.

You can access the contents of this book, and a possibly more updated version directly by going here:

frameworks.securityalliance.org

Disclaimer

This is not, by any means, an extensive guide on this subject or expected to be followed to the T. Its intention is to guide and provide hints as to where to apply security. This will vary depending on case to case, or, in other words, the risks you expose yourself to, by specifically traveling.

The contents are free, public and open to anyone at the **Security Frameworks** official website. Feel free to suggest an update by contributing directly there.

Three-phase approach

This travel security mini-book is organized into three critical phases:

1. **Pre-travel preparation**: Risk assessment, device hardening, backup creation, and contingency planning.

2. **On-trip vigilance:** Network security, physical device protection, social engineering awareness, and maintaining operational security.

3. **Post-travel review**: Device inspection, account security verification, and lessons learned documentation.

Additional considerations are provided for high-risk travelers who may face targeted threats due to their role or access to valuable assets.

Before traveling

In this section you can expect all the things you should do before you depart. This includes hardening some devices and making sure you have a backup of the data you'll be traveling with. It also covers letting someone know you'll be calling in case of an emergency and how to identify you.

If you're already reading this while traveling, don't worry, this will still be helpful, it just might be a bit more challenging depending on your context.

To start, you can **remove or securely store** any data, devices, printed files, and documents **you don't absolutely need on the trip**. The less sensitive information and fewer critical assets you carry, the lower the risk and impact if loss, theft, or inspection occurs. Minimize your digital and physical footprint by leaving backups and originals securely at home or in trusted locations, and encrypt what must travel with you.

This principle applies to laptops, phones, hardware wallets, paper backups, and any portable storage media.

Perform a quick threat model

Take five minutes to map out your risks. Identify **what assets** you're carrying (laptops, phones, hardware wallets, seed phrases, account access), **who might target your assets** (thieves, cybercriminals, border agents, etc.). Lastly, **identify how attacks might happen** (device theft, tampering, malware, coercion). For each threat, plan a mitigation[1] if you feel this threat is applicable to you. For example, if you're carrying a hardware wallet, a threat is

1 https://youtu.be/igNa7z4hwMQ?t=2465

pick-pocketing – mitigation could be keeping it attached to yourself (just don't use ledger's necklace visibly) and securing it with PIN/passphrase (no patterns, not repeated across devices).

This exercise keeps security measures proportionate to your situation.

Secure devices with encryption & updates

Enable full-disk encryption on all devices (laptops, phones, tablets) to protect data if lost or stolen. Most modern OSes have them installed, not always enabled by default (e.g. BitLocker

for Windows, FileVault for MacOS, LUKS for Linux, or Android/iOS encryption – just ensure a strong password/PIN is set).

Use popular devices like iPhones and Pixels. **Install the latest** OS and app updates since these **patch security** vulnerabilities[2]. You can also consider to install — only trustworthy — mobile security applications[3], which try to add a layers of control and also reminds you of important security updates.

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2 A recent attack named **Pixnapping** has been recently uncovered, affecting many Android devices, particularly Pixels — www.pixnapping.com

3 On iOS, due to sandboxing, apps can't scan the entire OS for malware, so many security apps focus on VPN, phishing web protection, breach alerts, etc.

If you must bring high-risk confidential data, consider encrypting those files individually using tools like VeraCrypt, FileVault, BitLocker, LUKS/dm-crypt, or others.

Back up and prepare for loss

Back up your devices before travel (and ensure cloud backups like iCloud/Google are up to date). This way, if a device is lost or confiscated, you won't lose important information.

Record device details (make, model, serial numbers, IMEI for phones) and

keep that list separate – it will help in filing reports or remote-wipe commands.

If your company uses Mobile Device Management (MDM) on phones or laptops, **verify the device is enrolled** and you know how to trigger a remote wipe or "lost mode." Test "Find My" or equivalent device-finding services so you can use them if needed. Pack chargers and cables so you won't need to borrow unknown ones (which could be malicious).

Protect Accounts with 2FA redundancy

Plan for how you'll access accounts that use two-factor authentication if your main device is unavailable. For authenticator apps (TOTP codes), **export backup codes** for your important accounts and keep them **securely** in services like 1Password or NordPass (you can check passwordmanager.com for more information on which one to pick).

Alternatively, consider storing them elsewhere physically[4]. If your 2FA is tied

4 You can write them on paper and keep them in a safe, or store them on an encrypted drive.

to a phone number (SMS or voice), disable SMS for 2FA. For technologies that are unfortunately dependent on phone numbers, **use a separate line** (not your personal one) from services like Google Voice, Burner App or SLYFONE. **Transfer your number to an eSIM** since they are harder to physically steal or swap than a physical SIM[5].

Ensure your password manager is accessible – many like 1Password have a **Travel Mode** that removes sensitive vaults from your device while you travel (you can restore them later). This limits

5 https://support.apple.com/en-ca/118227

exposure if your device is searched or seized[6].

You can also register a backup or alternative 2FA method, like a secondary phone (the device) or a **PIN-protected hardware key to be used as a passkey.** Be responsible with the use of software passkeys, particularly in situations where you are using a password manager to store both your passwords and passkeys, as this creates a single point of failure.

6 https://www.schneier.com/blog/archives/2025/04/cell-phone-opsec-for-border-crossings.html

Secure your wallets and keys

Hardware wallets (e.g. Ledger, Trezor)

Update the firmware and test the device before you leave, don't do this while traveling. **Do NOT bring any written seed phrases** under any circumstance – seed backups are unencrypted keys that are far easier to steal or copy than a hardware device. Leave seed backups in a secure place, travel only with your hardware wallet if necessary. Enable all security features on the device (set a strong PIN, and use a

BIP39 passphrase for example, if supported) so that even if the device is stolen, the amount of information required to access your crypto, is high. Carry hardware wallets and security keys **in your carry-on or under your sight**, not in checked luggage, to avoid loss or tampering.

Yubikeys and 2FA tokens

Bring them to protect logins and make sure they're enabled on your critical accounts. **Keep them on your person or in a separate bag from your laptop/phone** so that a thief or snoop can't easily steal both at once. If you have a **spare hardware wallet or Yubikey**,

you might leave one at home as a backup in case the one you carry is lost. Add, when possible, an extra layer of security to the token, such as a PIN code.

Lock down phones

On your smartphone, **take advantage of security settings** before you travel. Set a strong passcode (not just a 4-digit PIN or pattern). Consider **disabling Touch ID/Face ID** if you might face situations where someone could force-unlock your device using your biometrics – in many jurisdictions, authorities can compel a fingerprint or face scan more easily than

a memorized password[7]. At a minimum, know how to quickly and **temporarily disable biometrics**[8]; for example, on an iPhone, holding the side button and a volume button will trigger an emergency mode that requires the passcode to unlock[9]. On Android, use **Lockdown** mode if available (which only temporarily disables biometrics and is different from iOS Lockdown Mode).

If you have an iPhone, enable **Lockdown Mode** (extreme protection on iOS) even if you are not at high risk or traveling to a

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7 https://www.schneier.com/blog/archives/2025/04/cell-phone-opsec-for-border-crossings.html
8 https://news.ycombinator.com/item?id=43630624
9 https://www.themacguys.com/essential-travel-security-tips-for-apple-devices

high-threat region – but be aware it restricts many features[10], though totally worth it.

Disabling or restricting USB debugging on Android and using iOS USB restricted mode helps prevent unauthorized physical USB access and **reduces risks from malicious cables** or compromised charging stations.

If your phone is managed by work (MDM), inform your IT team of your travel so they can assist with any location-based security policies and ensure you have the latest security

10 https://support.apple.com/en-gb/105120

profile. Finally, consider using a **dedicated eSIM/local SIM** for travel data. This can protect your primary phone number (you can keep your main line on eSIM and turn it off, while using a local data eSIM for mobile internet) and avoids physical SIM issues.

Configure additional phone protections

On **iOS devices**, **disable Control Center and Notification Center** access from the lock screen (Settings > Face ID & Passcode) to prevent thieves from seeing notifications or enabling Airplane Mode without unlocking. **Disable USB accessory connections when locked** to

prevent unauthorized connections. For device recovery, e**nsure Find My iPhone is enabled** with “Send Last Location" and “Find Network" options activated so tracking continues even if the device is powered off.

On Android, similar protections can be configured: disable notifications on lock screen (Settings > Notifications > On lock screen > Don't show notifications), and enable "Find My Device" with all location services.

PIN security

Many financial apps default to PIN verification instead of biometrics, which

means a thief who has your phone and knows your PIN could potentially access your financial accounts even if they can't bypass Face ID/Touch ID. Use unique PINs for banking apps that differ from your device PIN, or where possible, configure these apps to require biometric verification for every login.

Minimize digital & social media footprint

It's not just cyber threats – **operational security** matters. **Avoid announcing your travel plans publicly** on social media[11] and be careful with real-time

11 https://blackcloak.io/social-media-and-travel-be-careful-of-what-you-share/

updates. Posts about being away from home can signal to criminals that you (and possibly valuable devices or even your house) are vulnerable. Consider sharing trip photos and crypto conference highlights **after** you return or only with trusted contacts. Ensure your social media privacy settings are tightened so strangers can't see your travel posts.

When registering for events, use privacy-focused tools like iOS's Hide My Email or create burner emails through providers like Tuta. ProtonMail has had some controversy lately, but could still be a good alternative. If you don’t need to keep the inbox at all, just create a throw

away email account, there are plenty of options out there.

Avoid giving out personal details unnecessarily during registration — use minimal, generic info to reduce your digital footprint.

Discretion is key: if possible, don't advertise that you work in crypto[12] or carry cryptocurrency. For example, **remove or cover any crypto stickers on laptops or bags**, and avoid wearing company swag or Bitcoin/Ethereum logos while in transit. These can be neon signs attracting thieves or unwanted

12 https://www.unchained.com/blog/7-tips-traveling-bitcoin

attention (“I have valuable data or wallets!"). If asked about your work or luggage by curious strangers, have a **cover story** (e.g. “I work in finance/IT") rather than “I manage a crypto fund". High-profile team members might travel under pseudonyms or at least not list their company on luggage tags to stay low-profile. Also, be wary that you might be traveling with someone with these characteristics, so don't give them away.

Plan emergency and incident responses

Before departure, know what you'll do if something goes wrong. Have a

fallback plan in case of device loss: who will you notify & how (have safe words and beware of deepfakes or impersonations); how will you revoke access to sensitive accounts; and how will you continue working (e.g., a backup laptop or a colleague who can step in).

If traveling to countries with strict tech[13] or encryption laws[14] (e.g., China, Russia, UAE), **devices like VPNs, encrypted messaging apps** (Signal, or Telegram with Secret Chats only), hardware wallets (Ledger, Trezor), Yubikeys, or encryption software

13 https://www.perplexity.ai/search/countries-that-list-cryptopgra-bBSItefPSUi7HP2lTNekjA
14 https://it.cornell.edu/security-and-policy/travel-internationally-technology

(VeraCrypt, BitLocker) **may be flagged by border authorities**. Research local laws beforehand. Consider carrying a travel letter from your organization explaining the professional need for these tools, or use sanitized loaner devices to avoid issues at border controls.

Share your itinerary and contact information with a trusted peer so they can assist or monitor for any issues.

Finally, **schedule critical work** (especially high-value transactions) **for before or after your trip** if possible, so you're not forced to do ultra-sensitive actions on the road. Criminals usually

play with the "time-sensitive factor," trying to trick you into doing something quick and urgent, by committing something reckless.

There's more information for high profile individuals in the last chapter, page 70.

While traveling

In this section we're going to cover all the things you have to pay attention to or take care of while on the move. Is it necessary to connect to that conference's WiFi? Have you checked if there is a camera that might be recording your keystrokes? Leaving your computer unattended or just running whatever software your hackathon teammate asks you to download in order for your promising project to win might not be the best idea, it could result in compromise.

Network safety

Avoid untrusted Wi-Fi & Bluetooth. Treat **every network as potentially hostile**. Whenever possible, use a **cellular connection or a personal hotspot** instead of public Wi-Fi – your mobile data is encrypted and safer than an open cafe or hotel network. If you must use public Wi-Fi (hotel, airport, conference), verify the network name with staff and **disable auto-connect**[15] features so your devices don't join networks without prompting you.

15 https://www.cisa.gov/sites/default/files/publications/Cybersecurity%20While%20Traveling.pdf

Turn off Wi-Fi and Bluetooth on your phone and laptop when you're not using them; this reduces the risk of unsolicited connections or Bluetooth-based attacks. Also, disable any device-to-device sharing like **AirDrop** or **Nearby Share** to prevent strangers from sending you files[16].

Use a trustworthy VPN for an extra layer of encryption for your internet traffic, although in most cases by using an updated device, safe hardcoded DNS records, and ensuring SSL while browsing (enforce HTTPS-only-modes or adding “http://*” to your uBlock list) might be

16 https://www.cypherock.com/blogs/post-safe-vacation-tips-while-traveling-with-crypto

enough. A reputable, non-logging VPN (or your company's VPN) helps protect against snooping on public networks, especially if you're handling highly sensitive work and using several communication channels.

Using a personal portable router combined with a trusted VPN adds a strong layer of security when connecting to public Wi-Fi networks. This setup creates a private, encrypted tunnel between your devices and the internet, minimizing exposure to malicious actors on shared networks. Whenever possible, prefer mobile data over Wi-Fi, as cellular networks provide better encryption and isolation by

default. If you must use Wi-Fi, disable automatic connections and ensure you connect only to verified, trusted networks to reduce risk.

Device handling

Keep them close and protected. Never leave your devices (laptops, phones, hardware wallets) **unattended or unlocked in public**. Keep them on your person or within sight whenever possible. In a conference or cafe, use a cable lock for your laptop if you must step away briefly, take it with you or get someone you trust to watch it over for you.

In hotels/Airbnbs, **use the room safe** for small devices when you're out. These safes can easily be opened by an experienced thief or rogue/malicious staff. **Consider a portable travel safe/bag you can lock to a fixed object**.

A portable door lock[17] or door jammer for your room can add an extra barrier against intruders (useful in rentals without chain locks). This simple gadget prevents anyone (even with a key) from opening your door while you're inside. When out and about, be mindful of pickpockets – use bags that zip and

17 https://www.travelandleisure.com/sabre-portable-door-lock-review-7643179

consider a subtle anti-theft backpack for expensive gadgets or important assets.

For hardware wallets or Yubikeys, a good practice is to separate them from the device they authenticate: e.g. don't carry your Yubikey on the same keychain as your laptop bag key; keep it hidden on you. And, of course, **keep devices powered off** or locked when not in use – enable short auto-lock timeouts[18] on your phone/laptop so they aren't unlocked if snatched. You can also do this before leaving as well.

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18 www.cisa.gov/sites/default/files/publications/Cybersecurity%20While%20Traveling.pdf

Beware of unknown USB charging

Avoid plug-and-play charging stations at airports or malls. The risk of "**juice jacking**"[19], although small, is that a malicious charging kiosk or cable can inject malware or siphon data when you connect via USB. Depending on your profile risk, you might encounter technologies that mimic different kind of cables and accessories with the same purpose. These exist out of the box, and have been widely used by red-teamers and pentesters (re OMG cable).

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19 https://www.cypherock.com/blogs/post-safe-vacation-tips-while-traveling-with-crypto

Stick to using your own charger plugged into a power outlet, or use a **USB data blocker** (a little adapter that only passes power, not data). Similarly, do not plug unknown USB drives into your laptop – if someone hands you a free USB stick at an event, assume it could be a trap.

USBGuard[20] software (for Linux) or equivalent can be **used to restrict USB device access** on your computer, allowing only whitelisted devices. This tool can prevent an unknown USB from automatically tampering with your system by requiring authorization for

20 https://github.com/USBGuard/usbguard

new devices. At a minimum, disable any "USB autorun" features and consider locking down ports if your OS allows.

Screen privacy and social engineering

Practice situational awareness when working in public spaces. Shoulder surfing[21] is a real threat – someone nearby could be watching you enter passwords or PIN codes.

Use a **privacy screen filter** on your laptop or phone to narrow the viewing angle. This makes it much harder for

21 https://www.trio.so/blog/shoulder-surfing-in-computer-security

anyone not directly in front of your screen to read it. Sit with your back to a wall when possible, and shield the keypad with your body or hand when typing sensitive info.

In crowded conferences or airports, be cautious if someone you don't know strikes up conversation — might be trying to distract you or talk about crypto; scammers might engage you to glean info or even attempt to get you to unlock your device. **Don't log in to critical accounts in front of others** – you never know who's looking.

Also be mindful of phishing attempts: traveling users are prime targets for fake

“urgent" emails or messages. Double-check any unusual prompts before entering credentials, especially if you're on untrusted Wi-Fi[22] (use your VPN and look for HTTPS).

Maintain OpSec in public

While traveling, **blend in and stay discreet**. Refrain from discussing sensitive matters in public areas where eavesdropping is possible, or directly sharing things like where you are staying to people you don't know. Even hotel lobbies or ride-shares might not be secure for private discussions.

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22 https://www.cisa.gov/sites/default/files/publications/Cybersecurity%20While%20Traveling.pdf

When meeting people, don't give your phone to others to type down their socials, and remember to disable default options like Telegram's sharing phone number when adding a contact.

Remember that **hidden cameras or microphones** could exist in unfamiliar environments. It's rare but not unheard of, especially in Airbnbs or rented spaces – malicious hosts have hidden cameras in items like smoke detectors, clock radios, or USB chargers[23]. Give your accommodations a scan: look for odd or extra devices plugged in (especially

23 https://www.washingtonpost.com/travel/2024/05/22/hidden-cameras-airnbnb-rental-properties

facing beds or desks) and cover or unplug them if suspicious. You can also play ambient noise (or use a noise generator app) during confidential conversations to thwart any listening devices.

Keep a low profile

As mentioned, **don't flaunt crypto wealth or gear**[24]. For example, if attending a blockchain conference, consider using an alias on your name badge that doesn't explicitly say your company or title, and don't display that badge outside the venue. When moving around, secure your laptop in a

24 https://www.unchained.com/blog/7-tips-traveling-bitcoin

nondescript sleeve or bag (instead of one with a well-known conference brand). The goal is to avoid drawing the attention of both petty thieves and more organized attackers by limiting the signals that you're a high-value crypto target.

Don’t rely on security through obscurity. Going “stealth” doesn’t make you immune to attacks. The suggestions in this section are meant to complement, not replace, the other security measures.

Traveling with high-value crypto or duties

If you *must* make crypto transactions or access sensitive systems while on the road, do so with caution. Use trusted hardware and networks: e.g. if you need to send a transaction, use your hardware wallet on your own laptop (never a shared computer), on a secured connection.

Be aware of surveillance at events – attackers have been known to watch for people handling sensitive info. If you need to access a seed or enter a recovery

phrase, do it in a private, secure setting (never over public Wi-Fi or in view of anyone, including cameras).

Consider that **everyone knows you own crypto at a crypto event**[25], so your threat profile is elevated. Adjust your security: for instance, **enable a passphrase or a pin on any single-signature wallet** you carry so that even if someone obtains your hardware wallet, they can't access funds without that passphrase. For large amounts, rely on multi-sigs, veryfing payloads before signing – you might carry one key on you and leave another key(s) with trusted

25 https://www.unchained.com/blog/7-tips-traveling-bitcoin

parties so no single person has all signing power while traveling. In short, treat any on-trip crypto operations with more care than you would in the office or at home.

While presenting / doing public appearances

One often overlooked risk is the exposure caused by presenting or hosting technical workshops in public. Without properly hardening or isolating your computer before setting up, you may unintentionally expose network services to hostile environments or reveal sensitive information on-screen. Always prepare a clean, minimal

environment and verify no confidential data or open ports are accessible before connecting to unfamiliar networks or projecting your screen.

Physical safety and common sense

Operational security also has a physical aspect. **Trust your instincts** and normal travel safety rules: stick to well-lit and populated areas if carrying devices at night, don't let strangers "shoulder surf" your ATM or credit card PIN (check for skimmers, fake interfaces), and keep your travel documents secure since identity theft can be as damaging as device theft.

When possible, **store your devices in secure lockers** (many hotels or conferences offer charging lockers). Never leave them in open areas.

Beware of the classic "evil maid" scenario in hotels (where someone might tamper with your laptop in your room): using tamper-evident tape or seals on your laptop case can help detect this, though it's mostly a concern for high-risk targets. If you have tamper-evident stickers or tamper-evident bags, you can seal your device in them overnight – any attempt to open or remove the device will leave a visible trace. While not foolproof against a

determined adversary, it raises the bar and can deter casual snooping.

Petty thieves may look beyond obvious valuables. Simply locking items in a dorm safe or hiding them at home might deter casual theft, but savvy criminals often search inside books, behind electrical outlets, or within patterns on walls or furniture to find hidden stashes. Consider unconventional hiding spots and avoid predictable storage methods. Layer your physical security measures with tamper-evident seals or discreet decoy containers to raise the effort required for unauthorized access.

Above all, **maintain an alert posture**: be aware of who's around when you're working, and if something feels off (like someone persistently hovering or a device acting strangely), don't ignore it. You can always relocate, power down your device, or otherwise cut off exposure at the first sign of potential trouble.

There's more information for high profile individuals in the last chapter, page 70.

Returning home

Not in the literal sense of it, but **directed toward all the things you have to do after your travels**. From updating your processes based on experience to wiping exposed devices before rejoining them to your networks.

Secure your accounts and passwords

Once you're back, **if you suspect** that any account **credentials** you used while abroad **might have been exposed**

(especially if you had to log in over a hotel or conference Wi-Fi), address the issue. **Change passwords** for any accounts you accessed unsafely during the trip — but **if it doesn't seem necessary, be mindful that changing them unnecessarily can sometimes introduce additional risk.**

Do this from a trusted device/network (ideally wait until you're on your home or office network, not the airport Wi-Fi). Use this opportunity to upgrade weak passwords and ensure 2FA is still working on those accounts.

Check your email filters and crypto account settings for any unauthorized

changes (attackers sometimes add forwarding rules or new withdrawal addresses if they did get access).

Essentially, **rotate secrets** that may have been used under less-secure conditions.

Inspect and clean your devices

After traveling, give your devices a thorough once-over. Run a reputable anti-malware scan on laptops and phones. Look for any unusual apps, processes, or device behavior (for

example, unusual battery drain could indicate malware).

If you were in a high-risk environment or your device was out of your control at any point, consider wiping the device and restoring it from your pre-trip backup (or factory-resetting a phone) to ensure it's clean[26]. This is especially recommended for "burner" devices used on the trip – you can safely restore your data onto your main device and decommission the travel device.

26 https://architectsecurity.org/2017/10/mobile-device-security-for-international-travelers-part-3-how-to-clean-up-your-mobile-devices-after-international-travel

For hardware wallets, verify they weren't tampered with: check the device seals if any, and when you connect, **confirm the firmware is still legitimate** (if the manufacturer provides verification software). If you have any suspicion that a device (or hardware wallet) was compromised, *do not continue using it for sensitive transactions*. Transfer crypto assets to new wallets (using your seed backups in a new device if necessary) once you're on a secure network and device.

It's also a good idea to **disable or remove any travel-specific eSIMs or accounts** you used on the trip – for example, remove that foreign cellular plan from

your phone if you no longer need it, and uninstall any travel or conference apps that are no longer required.

Post-travel review

Now that you're home, **reflect on the trip** and note any security incidents or close calls. If any device was lost, stolen, or **even taken out of your sight and potentially tampered** (like held by airport security for a long inspection), inform your organization's IT or security team immediately. They may assist with forensic checks or account monitoring. Also inform colleagues if any work data might have been exposed so they can be vigilant. This is not about blame – it's about mitigating any damage early.

Re-enable any data or accounts you put in “travel mode." For instance, if you used 1Password Travel Mode to hide vaults, log in and turn those vaults back on. If you created throwaway emails or burner chat accounts for the trip, decide if you'll deactivate them now.

Update your threat model

Based on your experience: did any new threats emerge, or did some precautions prove unnecessary? Use that to improve future travel prep. Finally, share key lessons with your team. Sharing what you've learned from each trip and tweaking your security practices

contributes to a stronger security culture for everyone!

There's more information for high profile individuals in the following page.

Additional info for high-profile individuals

If you are a high-profile target, you'll evidently realize that some of these initial suggestions fall short within your threat model. **This section provides additional recommendations for profiles like yours.**

Web3 professionals who have **elevated privileges or profiles** – for example, access to multisig treasury keys,

leadership roles, or possession of sensitive organizational secrets are high-profile targets. These users may be targeted more deliberately by criminals or even nation-states. In addition to all the precautions above, high-risk travelers should take further steps.

For high-profile or recognizable individuals, **keeping a low profile is essential**. Beyond avoiding branded merchandise, a simple yet effective tactic is wearing an N95 mask or similar face covering. It's socially accepted, draws no attention, and helps protect your identity — making it harder for adversaries to target or track you during public events.

Use loaner or "burner" devices

If feasible, travel with clean devices that **don't contain sensitive data**. Leave your primary laptop/phone at a protected location (assuming you also have security in place as well), and bring a wiped, minimal laptop or a cheap travel phone with only the basics. Log into what you absolutely need (through secure channels) and nothing more. Treat these devices as expendable – assume they **will** be compromised and plan to wipe them afterward. For example, a senior developer might bring a laptop with no

source code on it and use a VPN or VDI (virtual desktop) to access company systems when necessary, leaving no data on the local disk. A hardware wallet keyholder might carry a **secondary hardware wallet** with lower privileges (or a single key to a multisig instead of full access).

Keep your primary keys secured in a location that is not accompanying you. Remember, a nearly empty device can raise suspicion at some borders, so don't make it obvious – load some innocuous data (music, generic files) so it looks used, but nothing that would be harmful if inspected.

Plan for customs and border checks

High-risk individuals may face increased scrutiny or device searches at borders due to the sensitive nature of their data or their roles (e.g., journalists). **Before crossing borders**, purge beyond recovery or secure sensitive information. Turn off devices before landing. Some experts even recommend **encrypting and then powering down** devices – a powered-off device with strong encryption is extremely hard to access[27].

27 reddit.com/r/technology/comments/1jl9dxg/how_to_lock_down_your_phone_if_youre_traveling_to

Disable cloud auto-sync of sensitive data; you don't want customs inadvertently accessing company cloud drives if they inspect your laptop. If asked to unlock devices, having them powered off gives you an opportunity to state that it's encrypted and requires a passphrase (which you should have memorized, not written down).

It's wise for high-risk travelers to **disable biometrics entirely before travel** – use PIN/password only, as mentioned – so you cannot be compelled or tricked via fingerprint/face.

Know your legal rights in the countries you transit; in some places you can refuse to unlock (though it may mean the device is held or you are denied entry), while in others you might face penalties. This is a personal risk decision – but the best case is to carry **nothing** truly incriminating or irreplaceable across a checkpoint.

For ultra-sensitive data, use secure communication channels to retrieve it at destination rather than carrying it. For instance, an executive could store confidential files in a secure cloud drive they access over VPN once abroad, rather than carrying them on a laptop.

Border/immigration checks often require you to share your travel plans, including hotel information and airline details. **Having a physical copy of them** (printouts, ingress-egress) **means you do not need to access your devices in front of agents or potential cameras while being scrutinized**. This will also prevent the need to let them peek at them to provide information, thereby risking the disclosure of sensitive personal information.

Since COVID, many nations have moved to digital immigration paperwork. This often requires the use of an email address. **You should consider a**

dedicated email address for interaction with government agencies, instead of an email address that might have a public/open-source affiliation with cryptocurrency (or other sensitive topics).

Enhanced device protections

High-risk users should layer additional defenses. **Lockdown Mode** (on iOS) or Android's equivalent secure modes should be enabled if there's any chance of targeted spyware (these modes disable

exploit-prone services and attachments). **Use messaging apps with end-to-end encryption and disappearing messages** (NOT Telegram, **Signal** is a good example) for any sensitive communications – assume that standard SMS or emails could be monitored.

Consider using a **Faraday bag** for phones when not in use, if you suspect active tracking or exploitation (this prevents any signals in or out, though use sparingly as it also blocks your calls).

If you leave a device in your hotel, you can put it in a tamper-evident bag and seal it, or at least take measures like

noting the exact placement or taking a photo, so you can detect if it was accessed.

Some high-risk individuals even **weigh their devices** before and after travel to detect the addition of hardware implants (a change in weight could indicate something like a chip added) – this is an extreme step, but shows the level of caution possible. At the very least, physically inspect your devices for new scratches, screws that look tampered with, or unexpected behavior.

Secure crypto keys with multi-party control

If you have access to significant crypto funds (exchanges, DAO treasury, etc.), **implement policies that prevent a single point of failure while you're traveling**. For example, if you're one of M-of-N multisig signers, consider temporarily **requiring an extra signer** for transactions while you're away (so if normally 2-of-3 can move funds, bump it to 3-of-3 or add a 4th backup signer) so that a compromised key or coerced action cannot alone execute a transfer.

If you hold hardware keys, keep them geographically split – e.g. bring one key device with you, leave the backup key in a safe place at home, and perhaps give a third key to a colleague, so that even a forced disclosure cannot result in an immediate loss of funds without collaboration. **Use duress codes if your hardware supports it** (some wallets allow a secondary PIN that opens a decoy account with minimal funds, the same can also be made with encryption volumes).

In general, **assume a determined adversary could target you** specifically for your role: use confidential communication to stay in touch with

your team (so they know you're safe daily), and establish a code word or protocol for emergencies.

High-risk travelers might also arrange a "check-in" schedule with their security team or colleagues – if you don't check in by a certain time, they can take pre-agreed actions (like disabling your accounts or alerting authorities). This kind of planning is an extra safety net when the stakes are especially high.

Post-trip device rebuilding

For highly targeted individuals, the safest course after returning is to **treat every device as compromised** and rebuild it, **especially before reaching your safe zone (home, work office).** This involves wiping devices to factory settings, flashing firmware if necessary, and restoring data from known-good backups made before the trip.

Consider using **read-only operating systems** or booting from trusted live media during travel to reduce risk exposure. Before your trip, you can

create a **cloned disk image** of a clean system state, so after traveling you can restore your device to that exact low-level copy — starting fresh with a known secure baseline. This approach helps eliminate stealthy malware or spyware that may have been implanted.

Additionally, **review system logs if available** (security apps or MDM solutions often report unusual access or configuration changes during your absence).

As always, report any suspicious incidents promptly. High-risk roles may require a debrief with your security

officer — be transparent about any odd encounters or possible security lapses to mitigate threats that could have followed you home.

Conclusion

Travel OpSec isn't about fear, it's about intention. You decide what to bring, what to leave behind, and how much risk you're willing to carry. The less you expose, the less you have to defend. Harden what matters, strip everything else, and stay aware of your surroundings.

Security on the road isn't a checklist you tick once. It's a posture you maintain. Updates, encryption, strong authentication, minimal data, trusted

paths — these are your baseline. From there, you layer additional controls according to your context. Some trips need burner devices and strict compartmentalization. Others just need good hygiene and awareness. The point is to make those decisions consciously, not out of habit or convenience.

When you return, assume that anything exposed has to be re-evaluated. Rotate credentials, wipe or rebuild if needed, and adjust your threat model based on what you experienced. Each trip should make you sharper, not more complacent.

Operational security — and I'd dare to say security in general — isn't about perfection. It's about making it harder for others to exploit you, and easier for you to recover if something happens. Keep the footprint small, act deliberately, and move through the world with clear eyes.

COVER BY

Constanza Tarantelli

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This work was written by **Matías Aereal Aeón** (matta) and is part of the **Security Frameworks** by the **Security Alliance** (SEAL), also currently led by him.

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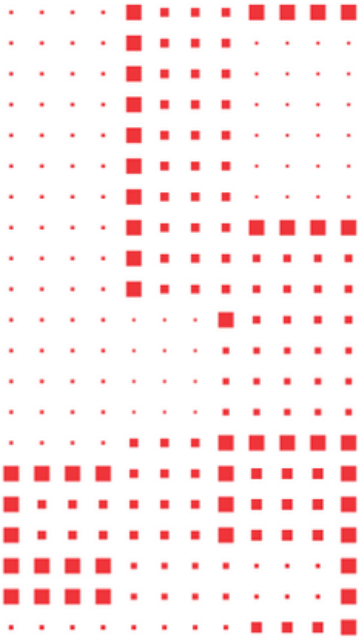

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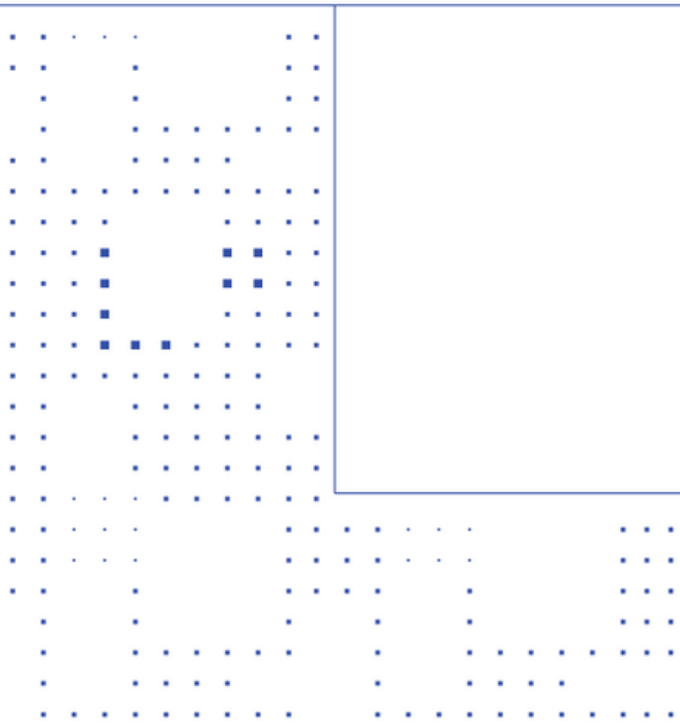
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